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Campaign aims to teach minority neighborhoods the value of a vote

"I'm registered to vote, but I don't," said 22-year-old John Bonet, standing on a sizzling sidewalk in Roxbury's Dudley Square on Thursday.

Why not, we asked the college student on lunch break from his summer lifeguard job.

"I won't until I see somebody who will put more into the community," Bonet replied.

Kamau Pritchard, 20 and a fellow lifeguard at the Madison Park Community Center, was even more cynical about politicians. "They say kids don't care about things, but they don't even ask us what we think. It's 'Lock 'em up and build more jails.' The only time we hear from them is at election time."

This is the type of alienation, so pervasive among the young, that a group of activists hopes to reverse with a nascent voter-mobilization drive in Boston's mostly minority neighborhoods.

"We've been meeting to develop a plan to maximize our voting strength," said Lloyd King, director of the Roxbury Action Program and a veteran community activist.

The effort, called 2000 Campaign for Political Respect, is coming off the drawing board. Other leaders include Doris Bunte, a former Boston Housing Authority administrator and state representative, and James Jennings, professor at the University of Massachusetts-Boston. King's brother, former mayoral candidate Mel King, is supporting the group, along with several dozen business, clergy, and civic leaders, King said.

The goal is to create a unique, nonpartisan electoral force of 2,000 voters in predominantly black and Latino neighborhoods.

In an appeal on the Boston Blacks Online Web site, the organizers declare: "We . . . call on 2,000 voters in Roxbury, Dorchester, the South End, and Mattapan not to spend your vote in the upcoming elections in September or November until you know what product you are buying from any of the candidates. Voters in these neighborhoods have been continually disrespected in terms of social and human services, economic development resources, and quality public schools. As long as we continue to support candidates in return for vague promises that are never implemented, we will continue to be disrespected and ignored. And sadly, our youth will continue to laugh when we say 'Register and vote.' "

There are no plans yet to endorse candidates, King said, but that could change, either in the 8th Congressional District primary or the governor's contest. Of 10 Democrats vying in the 8th, two live in the targeted neighborhoods – district City Councilor Charles Yancey of Dorchester and South Ender Alex Rodriguez, former chairman of the Massachusetts Commission Against Discrimination and, until this spring, deputy assistant US Treasury secretary. Both are underdogs, however.

Yet the mere existence of an organization aspiring to these goals could prod the slumbering giant – about 40,000 minority voters – in the upcoming 8th District Democratic primary. The urban district's population is about 40 percent black, Latino, and Asian, and most of Boston's minority precincts fall within its boundary. But the voting strength of these groups has long been diminished by chronic low turnout.

There have been exceptions – Jesse Jackson's presidential campaigns, and Mel King's 1983 mayoral run, which brought black and Latino voters en masse to the polls.

Nevertheless, Lloyd King and other organizers see an opportunity to begin reversing the pattern and make an impact in the 8th, where a minority-bloc vote could tip the race.

History doesn't favor the "2000 Campaign" activists. Previous efforts to pump up voting in Greater Roxbury have achieved mixed results, at best. In recent years, organizer Kevin Peterson tried, through the nonpartisan Part of the Solution, to expand registration. The campaign was a modest success, but is hamstrung by inadequate funding.

One obstacle has always been the linguistic and cultural diversity of the area. It is not, as the white political and business establishments tend to view it, homogeneous. It's home to Caribbean islanders who speak English, Spanish, or Haitian Creole; English-speaking blacks with Boston, Southern, West African, Caribbean, and Cape Verdean-Portuguese accents; and Latinos from Caribbean and Central and South American nations.

But common goals transcend cultural differences in those neighborhoods, which need the stabilizing influence of investments to create jobs and homeownership.

King and his band of optimists will try once more to build some elusive political strength through numbers. "It will allow us to bargain for respect," he said.

Political Circuit

BRIAN C. MOONEY



GLOBE STAFF PHOTO / SUZANNE KREITER

PRESIDENTIAL RECEPTION *Former president George Bush greeted Maxwell Taylor Kennedy (right), younger brother of Representative Joseph P. Kennedy II; Maxwell Kennedy's wife, Victoria; and their 8-day-old daughter, Noah, during a visit yesterday to the JFK Library in Dorchester.*

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CITY SPORTS

Finneran steps up pace in House

Shift by speaker follows public criticism from members

By Adrian Walker
GLOBE STAFF

News Analysis

By late yesterday, it was like none of it had ever happened. The breakaway revolt by House liberals, the fears that the legislative session would end with more broken promises.

Many of the issues that had appeared to be off the table were suddenly in the middle of the table, including more regulation for managed-care providers, an increase in the state's minimum wage, maybe even a ban on surcharges for automatic teller machines. House Speaker Thomas M. Finneran was even saying kind things about New England Patriots owner Robert Kraft.

But Finneran's adversaries were reluctant to claim victory, insisting that the sudden rebirth of several bills that had appeared moribund was simply business as usual. And it is true that the end of any legislative session is marked by a rush of activity. But clearly the sudden move to bring all those issues to the floor over Finneran's opposition represents a crack in the one-man rule that has characterized the House for the past two years.

Finneran seems resigned that Massachusetts is headed for a minimum wage increase he considers ill-advised, and regulation of HMOs that he may also oppose, but no longer feels able to block. The centerpiece of the HMO measure is giving patients the right to appeal decisions by their HMOs not to pay for certain procedures.

"I've lost before, I've taken it on the chin before, and my members know they're free to vote however they choose on those issues," he said.

In an unusual display, a group of representatives began plotting strategy privately and complaining about Finneran publicly, concerned that measures they backed would not see the light of day before the session ends July 31.

Finneran insisted yesterday that the concern had been overblown. He said that he had talked about HMO reform as a priority as far back as January and had always intended to bring the measure up for a vote. But he was critical of many of the aspects of the various bills that had been submitted, and the issue was bottled up in committee for months.

Finally, fed-up representatives moved to force the bill out of committee, and Finneran – though he would not admit it – yielded. The HMO legislation appears headed for the floor by late next week.

While representatives were concerned about the fate of some treasured pieces of legislation, they have also been alarmed by a growing public awareness that Finneran alone is setting the agenda for the House.

"Tom Finneran is someone who definitely has and maintains tight control over the agenda here," said Representative Jay Kaufman, a Lexington Democrat, "but he respects that there are a lot of us who care a great deal and have a responsibility to our constituents not to be silenced."

In recent days, Finneran has laid out an ambitious agenda – including major health care, education, and public safety initiatives. But he insists that the delays are nothing to be concerned about.

"I don't apologize for the fact that the budget and the tax cuts had to be resolved first," Finneran said. "But now they have been and I hope we can get these other issues resolved now."

The HMO and minimum wage bills are almost certain to pass the House, Finneran concedes. He may still block the ATM surcharge bill, which he characterizes as an attempt by the banking industry to have the Legislature resolve the industry's competitive issues.

But for the first time since losing an 82-80 vote in favor of restoring the death penalty last fall (a vote negated a week later), Finneran was effectively thwarted. Some legislators could barely contain their glee.

"If one-man rule worked," Kaufman said, "our forbears never would have come up with democracy."

Chinese exiles petition Boston officials for help

By Charles A. Radin
GLOBE STAFF

The efforts of Chinese exiles to petition Boston on behalf of colleagues imprisoned in the Hub's Chinese sister city, Hangzhou, are drawing a variety of reactions from Mayor Thomas M. Menino.

The petition drive – which has drawn support from Wang Dan, Chai Ling and Liu Gang, leaders of the 1989 pro-democracy movement which was bloodily repressed – was sparked by the Hangzhou city government's arrest of people trying to organize an independent political party.

The exiles want Boston officials to ask their Chinese counterparts to help free the detainees.

Menino's first reaction, Thursday night, was that he had never heard of Hangzhou. Hangzhou may have made Boston a sister city, mayoral spokeswoman Jacque Goddard added, but Boston never reciprocated.

By yesterday morning, the mayor's office had discovered that Boston and Hangzhou have had a mutual sister-city relationship for 16 years. But, Goddard said, "we haven't done anything with it." She deferred further questions to Antonio Nunziante of the city's office of special events and tourism, who incorrectly identified the sister-city association's last president and said it was no longer active.

But a source who has long been active in the association – who insisted on anonymity out of fear of mayoral pique – said the association is active, has sponsored at least three trips of Boston public school students to Hangzhou, and has hosted Hangzhou students and artists here.

And, the source said, in 1995 or 1996, the city threw a reception – attended by Menino – for visiting officials from Hangzhou.

City officials said they have no intentions of responding positively to the dissidents' petition.

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